

Cars for the masses

The very first cars from the late 19th century were hand built for the rich. The American industrialist Henry Ford (see pp.96–97) dreamed of building a car cheap enough for ordinary people to buy so, in 1908, he started making the Ford Model T. By bringing mass-production techniques to his motor car—which was made on an assembly line at low cost—Ford revolutionized car manufacturing. Today, there are more than a billion cars on the world's roads.

Most metal fittings on early cars were made of brass.



ONE MODEL

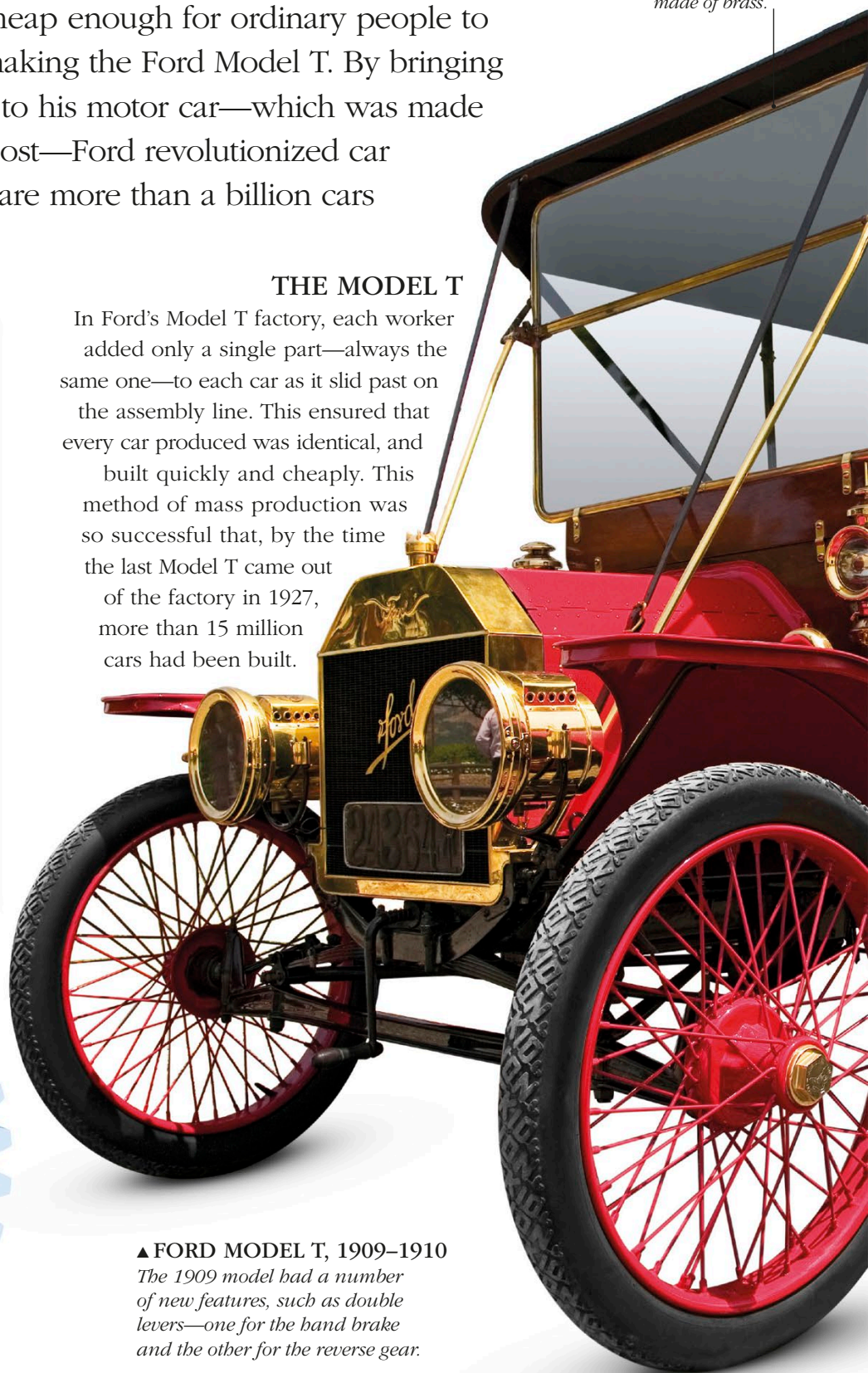
To keep costs down, it is said that Ford told customers they could have the car “in any color you like as long as it’s black.” This is a myth, since the Model T came in various colors. However, Ford pioneered the idea that all cars need to follow a standard template.

WOW!

Every year, cars burn 1.5 trillion gallons of oil—enough to fill more than two million Olympic swimming pools.

THE MODEL T

In Ford’s Model T factory, each worker added only a single part—always the same one—to each car as it slid past on the assembly line. This ensured that every car produced was identical, and built quickly and cheaply. This method of mass production was so successful that, by the time the last Model T came out of the factory in 1927, more than 15 million cars had been built.



▲ FORD MODEL T, 1909–1910

The 1909 model had a number of new features, such as double levers—one for the hand brake and the other for the reverse gear.